

ZHEJIAN WANG

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University of Delaware, Lerner College of Business and Economics

FIELDS & RESEARCH INTERESTS

Fields: Development Economics; Economics of Education (Human Capital); Industrial Organization (Digital Markets).
Research interests: Digital regulation and platform markets; technology policy and institutional design; human capital formation.

EDUCATION

- **University of Delaware, Lerner College of Business and Economics** 2020 – 2026 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics Newark, DE, USA
 - **Dissertation:** Essays in Digital Economics
 - **Selected coursework:** Econometric Theory I–II; Time-Series Econometrics; Topics in Dynamic Modeling; Cross-Section and Panel Data; Development Economics; Household Finance (Theory & Empirics); Labor Economics
- **University of Southern California** 2016
M.A. in Economics Los Angeles, CA, USA
- **Southwestern University of Finance and Economics** 2014
B.S. in Management China

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

- **Restricting Video Games in China: Effects on Time Use, Educational Achievement, and Health**

Sole-authored. *Under review.*

Abstract: Screen time regulation for minors is among the most widely adopted digital policies globally, yet credible causal evidence on its effects remains scarce. I study China's 2021 regulation, which virtually eliminated weekday online gaming for minors and limited play to one hour on weekends/holidays—the strictest intervention of its kind. Using nationally representative CFPS data (2020, 2022) in a difference-in-differences design, I find sharp declines in minors' gaming and total Internet use but no robust improvements in study effort, academic performance, or physical health, with suggestive declines in mental well-being. A complementary Regression Kink design using city mock-exam data around the age-18 cutoff likewise shows no exam effects. The null results on human capital despite effective compliance challenge the assumptions underpinning screen time regulation worldwide and inform ongoing policy debates in the US, EU, and elsewhere.

Working Papers

- **Digital Regulation and Market Responses: Evidence from Chinese Mobile Apps**

Sole-authored.

Abstract: This paper studies how China's 2021 gaming restriction for minors reshaped digital markets using app-level downloads and revenues. Difference-in-differences and event-study estimates show sharp declines in youth-oriented games, smaller effects for adult-oriented titles, and growth in substitutes such as e-books and social media. Usage shifts away from weekdays and toward permitted weekend hours, consistent with strategic adaptation by users and firms. Market responses are heterogeneous, including rebranding, monetization changes, and advertising re-targeting. Ongoing work examines longer-run firm dynamics (entry/exit) and innovation responses.

- **From Seats to Status: China's 1999 Higher-Education Expansion and Urban–Rural Occupational Mobility**

with Yiqun Tong and Ruoming Zhang. *Under review.*

Abstract: Using China's 1999 higher-education expansion as a cohort-based supply shock, we study rural–urban occupational mobility. We construct an LLM-based occupational socioeconomic-status score from free-text job descriptions in the 2015 1% Population Sample Survey. Post-expansion rural cohorts gain 0.25 points in occupational status relative to urban cohorts (closing approximately 17% of the raw gap). IV evidence supports a causal education channel: each additional year of schooling raises occupational status by about 0.21 points, with upgrading concentrated in moves from low-skill manual work into skilled trades and basic services.

- **When Success Becomes Salient: Local Role Models and Schooling Decisions**

with Ruoming Zhang. *Under review.*

Abstract: We study whether highly visible academic “superstars” generate local human-capital spillovers by shifting beliefs and inducing schooling responses. Using microdata from China's 2010 Population Census, we construct county-by-cohort exposure to the first emergence of a provincial Gaokao top scorer (1990–2005) based on the top scorer's high-school location. Exploiting staggered timing across counties, we estimate event-study and staggered difference-in-differences models comparing cohorts in exposed counties to contemporaneous cohorts in not-yet-exposed counties. Exposure increases educational attainment for cohorts plausibly able to respond—students one to two years younger than the top scorer. In this window, exposure to a science-track top scorer reduces dropout, raises years of schooling by 0.267 years, and increases tertiary attainment, with four-year college completion rising by 2.9 percentage points.

• Premarital Property Rights and Marriage Timing: Evidence from Urban China

with Ruoming Zhang. *Under review*.

Abstract: In 2011, China's Supreme People's Court strengthened individual property rights over premarital housing, reducing expected redistribution upon divorce. We exploit this legal shock to estimate how property rights affect marriage timing in the presence of high housing costs. Using 2010 and 2015 census microdata, we implement a difference-in-differences design combined with entropy balancing. We find a distinct gender asymmetry: the reform significantly reduces marriage entry for young women in high-housing-price cities, while men's outcomes remain largely unchanged. Women in high-price areas experience an approximately 3 percentage point decline in marriage rates relative to low-price cities. The results suggest that stronger premarital property rights reduce marital surplus for non-owners, incentivizing marriage delay.

• Less Paperwork, More Marriages: Registration Frictions and Marriage Outcomes

with Ruoming Zhang. *Draft available upon request*.

Abstract: We study how lowering administrative barriers to legal marriage affects marriage timing and match composition in urban China. The 2003 Regulations on Marriage Registration removed key documentary requirements, sharply reducing registration frictions. Using 2010 China Population Census microdata and a monthly regression discontinuity in time design, we find a sizable increase in first-marriage registration at the cutoff of about 3.7 per 1,000 unmarried urban residents per month, with effects persisting beyond the implementation month. The reform also shifts match outcomes: spousal age and education gaps change and cross-jurisdiction marriages rise, especially inter-provincial unions for men, while cross-hukou pairing changes little. "Shotgun" marriages increase and premarital births decline, consistent with accelerated legalization around childbearing. Using a retrospective stability proxy (whether marriages formed near the reform remain intact by 2010), we find no discontinuity in marital stability at the cutoff.

Work in Progress

• Generative AI as a Product Feature: Causal Evidence from iOS Apps

Sole-authored.

Building a daily panel of Top-1000 iOS apps (2020–2025) with version histories to estimate the causal effect of adopting generative AI features on app revenue, downloads, and growth. Uses staggered event-study designs with within-category spillover decomposition.

• Legal Clarification and Judicial Consistency: Evidence from China

Sole-authored.

Using publicly available court judgments and the 2011 Supreme People's Court Judicial Interpretation (III) as a sharp legal shock, I test whether clarifying legal rules reduces judicial discretion and increases consistency in marriage property dispute adjudication.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

• University of Delaware

Fall 2022 – Spring 2023

Instructor

Newark, DE, USA

- Introduction to Microeconomics (ECON 101), Fall 2022
- Introduction to Macroeconomics (ECON 103), Spring 2023

• University of Delaware

Fall 2021 – Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant

Newark, DE, USA

- Graduate: Microeconomic Theory I–II (ECON 811, 813). Undergraduate: Data Analysis for Economics (ECON 306), Quantitative Micro Theory (ECON 301), Urban Economics (ECON 393), Health Policy (ECON 490), Management Information Systems (MISY 261).

FELLOWSHIPS & RESEARCH FUNDING

• Graduate Fellowship, University of Delaware

2020 – 2025

• Third-Year Summer Research Stipend, University of Delaware

Summer 2023

• Research Assistant to Prof. David Stockman, University of Delaware

Spring 2024

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

• Caitong Securities Co., Ltd. — Internet Industry Research Division

2017 – 2020

Assistant Analyst (2017–2018); Analyst (2019–2020)

Shanghai, China

- Covered digital platform firms and technology regulation as a sell-side equity analyst; this experience motivated my academic research on digital economics and market responses to regulation.
- CFA charterholder.

SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Software: Stata, R, Python, L^AT_EX, SQL. **Languages:** Mandarin Chinese (native); English (fluent).

PRESENTATIONS

University of Delaware Economics Seminar Series (Dec. 2025); University of Delaware ESGA Conference (Oct. 2025).

REFERENCES

1. **Jeremy Tobacman**
University of Delaware
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2. **George R. Parsons**
University of Delaware
Email: gparsons@udel.edu
3. **Emily L. Battaglia**
University of Delaware
Email: emilylb@udel.edu
4. **Desmond J. Toohey**
Securities and Exchange Commission (formerly University of Delaware)
Email: desmondtoohey@gmail.com